competition. In the late 1980s, business opportunities were lost and ‘with some notable exceptions Tata companies seemed’ to have been ‘overshadowed by leaner, more-innovative competition’, commented *The Asian Wall Street Journal*. As Krishna Kumar said in 2000, reflecting on this, ‘The realization [was] clear now that the Group needs a strong focus. Everything else is incidental to the central task of performance.’

Ratan clarified to *The Asian Wall Street Journal* in 1993: ‘What I’m seeking is to create a sense of belonging to a single group, a sense of pride in belonging to the Tatas.’ He set out to achieve ‘group spirit’ and guarantee the quality of the group’s goods and services through eleven initiatives. Of these, one, the Strategic Plan 2.0, was formulated by him just before he became group chairman. The rest were conceived after he rose to the position: increasing the stake of Tata Sons in Tata companies; the JRD QV Award and the Tata Business Excellence Model (TBEM); the Tata Brand Equity and Business Promotion Agreement; the Tata Code of Conduct; the Group Executive Office (GEO); the Group Corporate Centre (GCC); the Corporate Assurance Group (CAG); the Group Strategic Forum (GSF); the Tata Business Review Committees (BRCs); and consumer focus.

These initiatives were at the heart of the reformation Ratan engineered. The strategies mutually reinforced each other in a synergistic architecture and laid a new foundation for the group. And this was what his tenure at the Tata Group’s helm would be most remembered for, as he reinvented the Tata enterprises and ensured their survival and prosperity. As R. Gopalakrishnan, who was a member of the GEO says: ‘The ideas to strengthen the group glue were far-sighted and those were the need of the hour at that time.’

Increasing Stake in Tata Companies

India’s tryst with economic liberalization and Ratan’s appointment as chairman, Tata Sons, were contemporaneous events. For the country, the liberalization signalled the beginning of a wave of economic reforms and for the Tata Group, it was a phase of new challenges and opportunities. Ratan was quick to get off the ground.

Amongst the first initiatives he took was to increase the perilously low stakes of Tata Sons in its companies to insulate them from hostile takeovers. The average holding of Tata Sons in the nine listed entities out of ten